production of Vitamin D that helps strengthen the immune system and other functions in the human body, but too much of it can be destructive. Skin pigmentation plays the role of a regulator of UV-B rays. In tropical Africa, where as per current knowledge the origins of Homo sapiens are said to be, the high intensity of UV-B rays led to more production of a compound called melanin to serve as a natural sunscreen and, consequently, darker skin. Closer to the poles, or at higher latitudes, the annual average UV radiation on the earth's surface is far less than in the tropics. Also, the UV-B rays are more scattered by the atmosphere due to the Earth's tilted rotational axis. As human beings moved outside the tropics, they were moving to areas that received less intense UV-B rays. The evolutionary response was a change in pigmentation or less production of melanin to absorb UV rays more efficiently. Consequently, this led to lighter skin colours.

The empirical support for this elegant theory on the evolution of skin colouration is of recent vintage. Charles Darwin (1809-82) was a keen observer of traits, even commenting on the people of India as we shall see later, but he had famously rejected this theory.[5] Among other grounds, he pointed out that Dutch families did not undergo the 'the least change of colour after residing for three centuries in South Africa'. But evolution, as we now know, is a very gradual process taking place over thousands of years. This is why, in the modern world of substantial cross-latitudinal migration, people stand to face health risks when they live in latitudes with different UV-B ray intensities from what had dictated their skin colour from an evolutionary perspective.[6] Advances in the sciences, which in the past also led to spurious claims of racial superiority on the basis of skin colour, have now made more people aware about the follies of racism and the solar links with skin pigmentation. When Indians go to places in the northern hemisphere with less exposure to the sun, the big D associated with their skin may no longer be Discrimination but deficiency of Vitamin D.[7]

Back home though, many Indians are less concerned with vitamins and more with fairness creams. Whether such an obsession about looking whiter than the rest emerged from the colonial era or much earlier is difficult to trace, but the natural colour gradient from lighter skins in the extreme north